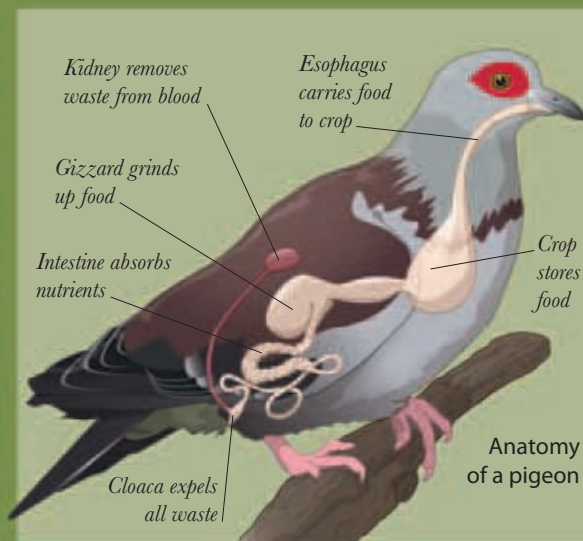




Outdoor pantry

Many mammals and birds store seeds. Acorn woodpeckers make their stores out in the open, by jamming acorns into holes that they drill in trees. They work in groups, filling their store with up to 50,000 acorns, which they carefully guard. Many other birds store seeds by burying them in the ground. Amazingly, they can remember the location of thousands of seeds, months after they were hidden away.



Digesting seeds

Birds do not have teeth, so they cannot chew seeds or other foods. Instead, they often swallow small seeds whole, after removing the husk. The food then enters a storage chamber called the crop, before moving to the gizzard—a muscular chamber that grinds it up. Birds often swallow stones, which become lodged in their gizzard, helping it to break up the food.

Nutcracker

The hyacinth macaw is the largest flying parrot, with the strongest beak of any bird. It can exert a pressure of 2,100 lb per sq in (150 kg per square cm), enough to crack open extra-hard palm nuts. Like other parrots, it uses its feet to hold its food, while it turns nuts into the right position with its stubby tongue.



Top half of beak hinges with skull

Tongue

Narrow tip of beak digs kernels out of nuts

Jaws crush food into a pulp before it is swallowed

Foot with four fleshy toes tipped with long claws